

Phenomenon and noumenon



In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, Kant wanted to find the limits of what we can apprehend and subject to reasoning. We apprehend things only through bodily experience, but there may be things that we cannot experience, but which nevertheless exist in reality. There are, Kant explains, two worlds: the world as we experience it through our senses, and the world as it is in itself. What our senses tell us is not complete – what we see, hear and touch gives us *information* about a thing, but that is not the thing itself. Kant made the distinction between the *noumenon*, the thing-in-itself, and the *phenomenon*, the thing as we experience it. The noumenal world is

transcendental – it exists beyond our experience and apprehension. But we perceive the phenomenal world through our senses and the categories of understanding, so it is both empirically real *and* transcendently ideal. Kant called his theory ‘transcendental idealism’. So, while science can discover things about the phenomenal world, the nature of reality independent of experience will always be beyond our understanding.